The Illusion of the Given

A Plain English Version



Introduction: The Puzzle of Agreement

Whenever different people look at the world and describe the same things, our minds jump to a be lief: this agreement must come from an objective thing that sits behind what we see. If two people look at a river, or if a human, an animal and an insect cross the same patch of ground, common sense insists there must be an underlying physical something that each of them simply registers through its own senses.

Indian and Tibetan Buddhist philosophy explores this puzzle with a famous example: a single bowl of liquid, seen by different kinds of beings.

- To a human, it is clear, refreshing water.
- To a hungry ghost, driven by deep habits of craving and lack, it is foul pus and blood.
- To a fish, it is the air it breathes and the home it lives in.
- To a god in a heavenly realm, it is delicious nectar.
- To an awakened being, it appears as the pure wisdom-form of water: the female Buddha Māmakī.

Everyday realism explains these differences with a two-layer picture. We assume that some raw, neutral stuff (water molecules, bare matter, or physical energy) sits in that spot, and that each creature looks at it through different biological and mental lenses.

The Middle Way of Nāgārjuna and the Great Perfection (Dzogchen), read without a foundation, both reject this picture. Examined closely, the idea of a shared thing that exists by itself, beneath all the ways it appears, falls apart. This insight also has echoes in modern physics and philosophy of science, especially relational quantum mechanics and Karen Barad's agential realism. They are used here only as illustrations, not as proofs. If we took them to mean that relations are the real bedrock, we would only have built another floor.

Agreement does not need a hidden bedrock. Regular patterns do not need a foundation. When conditions change, how things appear changes, not because different observers decode one un-touched object in different ways, but because the thing seen, the one seeing and the way they meet are all identified together, each depending on the others. And the relations between things are just as impossible to pin down as the things themselves.

1. The Trap of the Hidden Substance

Saying that different creatures "see the same liquid differently" slips in a word we have not examined: *the liquid*. It assumes that before anyone meets it, an object is already there, with its own identity, waiting to be seen.

This is the old idea, made famous by Kant, of a "thing-in-itself" hidden behind our senses:

- **The claim:** a thing-in-itself exists beyond our awareness, and living beings project their own mental categories, space and senses onto it.
- **The Middle Way reply:** if this hidden thing exists before and apart from all experience, what is it like? If it has definite qualities, such as being thirst-quenching water, it cannot explain why the hungry ghost meets burning pus. If it has no qualities at all, a featureless blank cannot cause any experience whatsoever.

Kant himself never said the thing-in-itself causes things the way one event causes another inside experience. But he did call it the "non-sensible cause" of appearances, and that is exactly where his critics found the weak point.

The "Wet-and-Moist" Objection

A thoughtful person will push back: "Why must the hidden thing be water or pus? Why can't it simply be wetness, the basic quality that water and pus share?"

It is a natural suggestion. Buddhist psychology lists wetness and moisture as the defining mark of the water element, shared by anything liquid. But the suggestion meets a fork in the road:

1. **If wetness is claimed as a thing that exists by itself:** the argument fails. Wetness in general is an abstraction made by thought. In real life, wetness never floats free; it only ever shows up as *this* drinkable water, *this* foul pus, or *this* water a fish lives in. And being fluid is itself a meeting between things: what is liquid to a large living body is not liquid in the same way to systems working at very different scales or through different forces.
2. **If wetness is treated as an everyday, agreed reference point:** then it is no longer a hidden thing-in-itself. It becomes a good example of an acceptable working label: a practical term that lets people compare and discuss different viewpoints, without pretending to point at a bedrock that exists apart from all observers.

What Nāgārjuna's analysis targets is *svabhāva*: an imagined nature that a thing would have all by itself, depending on nothing. A "neutral substance" placed beneath appearances is just that imagined nature in a modest disguise.

2. Agreement Without a Hidden Substance: The Middle Way Account

If there is no hidden object behind appearances, why do humans reliably agree that the liquid is water? Why doesn't the shared world fall apart into private fantasies?

The Indian master Candrakīrti, in his *Entering the Middle Way*, turns the question around. Agreement does not prove there is a hidden object. Shared, reliable agreement is simply what conventional truth, everyday truth, is.

A. Mind and Object Depend on Each Other

Candrakīrti spends many verses taking apart the Mind-Only view, which tries to solve the puzzle by getting rid of outer objects and making a truly real consciousness the only foundation. He shows that mind and object depend on each other:

- A seeing cannot be identified without what is seen.
- An object cannot be identified without the senses and concepts that pick it out.

Neither mind nor matter comes first. Making the mind the container of everything is just as mistaken as making matter the container.

B. Healthy Senses and Faulty Senses, Within Each Kind of Being

Candrakīrti distinguishes what the world itself accepts as true from what even the world sees as false, according to whether the senses are healthy or impaired, for example by an eye disease. Later writers called these correct and mistaken conventions. The standard examples are a person with jaundice who sees a white conch shell as yellow, and a person with an eye disease who sees hairs floating in the air.

The key point is that whether a sense is faulty can only be judged within one kind of being:

- A human with jaundice sees the white conch as yellow. Because other humans with healthy eyes see it as white, the jaundiced person is mistaken by human standards.
- The hungry ghost, however, is not a "jaundiced human". By the standards of its own kind, its senses are working normally. It is not suffering an optical illusion of water; for it, the liquid really does function as pus.

This sorting into correct and mistaken is made from the world's point of view. Candrakīrti adds that noble beings, who have let go of the deepest confusion, see all such things as like reflections: for them they are "mere conventions", not truths.

C. A Working Reference Point

To avoid falling into nihilism, the view that nothing exists at all, this article draws a distinction in the spirit of Tsongkhapa's reading. He treats the hungry ghost's seeing of pus as a conventional perception shaped by its karma, not as a mere mistake. (The Tibetan terms used for this in the full article are the author's own working terms.)

What Is Negated	What Is Conventionally Accepted
A shared base that exists by itself: a physical substance with its own identity, there before anyone perceives it.	A working reference point: a label, made in dependence on conditions, for the place where different ways of appearing meet and can be compared.

What stops this reference point from sliding back into a hidden thing-in-itself?

It is not a carrier of qualities that exists before its relations. It has no qualities beyond those that show up through some particular channel of contact. It is a label made from within one everyday frame, usually the human one, so that different viewpoints can be compared. Its job is to coordinate, not to sit underneath. It does in the Middle Way what "cross-perspective links" do in relational quantum mechanics (Section 5), not what a substance does in old-fashioned realism.

D. Where the Bowl Example Came From: Vasubandhu, and Candrakīrti's Reply

The bowl example did not begin in the Middle Way. In his *Twenty Verses*, Vasubandhu used the hungry ghosts to defend the Mind-Only view. Critics asked: if there are no objects outside the mind, why do our experiences agree? Why do many beings see the same thing at the same place and time? Vasubandhu answered that, just as hungry ghosts with the same karma all see a river of pus together, shared karma ripening in consciousness explains shared experience. No river outside the mind is needed.

That answers our very question by making consciousness the floor. Candrakīrti turned the example around. He compared the hungry ghost seeing pus to someone with an eye disease, and concluded: just as the object does not exist on its own, neither does the mind. If the pus has no standing because it is not outside the mind, the seeing of pus has no better standing, because object and seeing are identified together. For the hungry ghost, the river of pus and the seeing of it stand or fall together.

In everyday terms, both the object and the mind are accepted. Under analysis, neither can be found existing by itself. So the bowl does not show that the world is inside the mind. It shows that neither the world nor the mind is the floor. Shared karma, the "karmic vision" that beings of one kind have in common, is still part of the explanation of why they agree. But it is one condition among many, not a storehouse consciousness in which the world is really kept.

3. Other Observers

Agreement needs others to agree with. This raises three questions: how we know other observers exist at all, whether this account of agreement goes in a circle, and what part language plays.

A. Other Minds

Shared experience assumes that there are other observers whose experience could match mine. But how do we know? Indian philosophers debated this directly. Dharmakīrti argued that we infer other minds: other bodies move and speak with purpose, as mine does when I intend something. Later, Ratnakīrti, writing from the Mind-Only view, argued that other minds can never finally be proven.

Both assumed something this article rejects: that my own experience is certain, while yours is only inferred or doubtful. The Middle Way refuses this imbalance. Examined closely, my stream of mind is no more findable than yours; both are identified in dependence on changing physical and mental parts, and both work in daily life.

The certainty I feel about "my" experience and the doubt I feel about "yours" are the same habit of solidifying things, turned inward, making the self the one unquestionable floor. In everyday life the world accepts other minds as plainly as it accepts tables, and nothing reliable contradicts it. Other observers are not a conclusion drawn from a private starting point. They are identified together with this one, as "long" is identified together with "short".

B. Is Agreement Circular?

A critic can press a point. Senses count as healthy when they agree with others of their kind, and the kind is defined by sharing those senses. The standards define the group, and the group defines the standards. Isn't that circular?

It is, and the circle is not a flaw. It would be fatal only if agreement had to rest on something outside itself: a final judge who is not one more participant. The Middle Way denies that there is any

such judge. Here the dependence runs both ways, just as ways of knowing and things known are each established only in relation to the other. Nothing is being built on a foundation, so there is no missing foundation for the circle to lack.

The philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein reached a similar point by another route. What makes following a rule possible is agreement "not in opinions but in form of life", and communication through language needs agreement not only in definitions but also in judgements. Agreement is not evidence of a hidden object behind it. It is simply convention doing its work.

The circle does not make mistakes impossible. Inside it, correction is real: the jaundiced eye is corrected by others, a misreading by a second look. What the circle rules out is only a correction from outside every point of view.

C. Language

For humans, the frame that keeps track of agreement is, to a large degree, language. Words are learned from others, corrected by others and shared with others. A child learns "water" as a word that works: say it, and a glass is brought. That is why humans agree so finely, not only that liquid is there, but that it is water, that it is cold, and that it is the same water as yesterday's.

Identifying things is wider than words. Animals pick out their world by sensing and responding, without language, and their worlds are coordinated too. But language carries human agreement across times and places that no single glance could reach. It is also where the habit of solidifying is strongest: the noun "the bowl" seems to point to a solid thing standing behind every view of it. The same tool that coordinates our worlds tempts us to believe it describes one world hidden behind them.

4. The Experiential Side: Dzogchen Without a Foundation

The Middle Way uses careful reasoning to take apart fixed beliefs, and it rests content with everyday convention. Dzogchen, the Great Perfection, describes how appearances are met in experience, in a vocabulary of its own.

A. The Basis Is Not a Hidden Substance

In the Dzogchen of Longchenpa and Mipham, the basis is primordially pure, and it is carefully distinguished from the "storehouse consciousness" that keeps karmic habits.

- The basis is described through three inseparable aspects: its essence, which is empty (this is **primordial purity**); its clarity, which is **spontaneous presence**, appearing without obstruction; and **compassion**. This article takes up only the first two. It does not explain compassion as a cosmic force, or as a power belonging to the basis.
- Primordial purity means that the basis has no solid, independent existence at all. It is not a hidden block of stuff, a cosmic mind or a starting point of the world. Longchenpa says the basis is called a "ground" only from a relative point of view; in the true nature of things, it is empty of being any ground, and free from every extreme. "True nature" here means simply the way things are, not an essence.

B. Self-Display: Ordinary Mind and Pure Awareness

Appearances are described as "display", appearing as self-display. "Display" must never be heard as the display of something standing behind it. It means dependent arising itself, vivid and unobstruc ted, with nothing behind it.

To keep this from sliding into "everything is mind", or into a hidden mind that creates the world, Dzogchen distinguishes ordinary dualistic mind from pure awareness, *rigpa*:

- **The grasping subject is part of the display.** The feeling of being a subject inside, looking out at a world, is itself an appearance, arising together with the object outside. Neither mind nor matter produces the other; both arise together within the display.
- **Awareness is not a projector.** Rigpa is not one half of the subject-object pair, not a subtle mind-stuff that sends out forms, and not a ground behind appearing. It is the knowing of the basis: recognising appearing as unfixed, dependent and empty. The clarity of appearances belongs to the appearances themselves, not to a separate knower, and like the appearances, it is empty.
- **Display is not cause and effect.** The basis does not produce appearances the way a cause produces an effect. Spontaneous presence is not an uncaused engine turning out conditioned things. Appearing is already complete, owing its completeness to nothing hidden, and it is empty from the very moment it appears.

C. Self-Knowing Awareness: A Deliberate Choice

Here the traditions divide. Candrakīrti rejected self-knowing awareness, citing a sūtra on the point. Śāntideva later made the argument famous with the image of a sword that cannot cut itself. Follow ing Candrakīrti, Tsongkhapa rejected self-knowing awareness even as an everyday convention.

On this point the article deliberately follows Mipham:

- **Ultimately,** Mipham fully accepts the Middle Way refutation. Under analysis, no self-knowing awareness that exists by itself can be found. It is empty like everything else.
- **Conventionally,** Mipham keeps self-knowing as a useful everyday term, to explain memory and the immediacy of experience without an endless chain of minds watching minds. This is not the self-awareness of the Mind-Only school that Candrakīrti refuted, which was offered as proof of a truly existing consciousness. It is a convention, and empty like every convention.
- In Dzogchen, the self-knowing of rigpa is not a real subject looking at itself as an object. It is simply the absence of confusion: the immediate, natural clarity of recognising appearing as empty display, belonging to no one.

This reading of Mipham is the author's own, from repeated study of his works. *The Observer and the Taste of Presence* (Chapter 19) leaves the question open. This article takes Mipham's side on the everyday status of self-knowing, and on that point only.

D. Mipham's Four Kinds of Valid Knowing, and Pure Vision

Mipham sets out four kinds of valid knowing, two for everyday truth and two for ultimate truth:

1. **Ordinary everyday knowing:** works within the shared karmic vision of beings in saṃsāra. The gods belong here too: their nectar is a refined karmic vision, not awakened vision.
2. **Pure everyday knowing:** belongs to awakened beings, for whom the liquid appears as Māmakī, the female Buddha of the water element.

3. **Ultimate knowing through concepts:** the understanding of emptiness reached by reasoning.
4. **Ultimate knowing beyond concepts:** the direct realisation of the inseparable unity of primordial purity and spontaneous presence.

How does this fit with Candrakīrti's account in Section 2B? Mipham holds both together. Within ordinary vision, validity is relative to each kind of being: the hungry ghost's pus is normal by hungry-ghost standards, and the human's water is normal by human standards. Neither has the last word over the other. But between ordinary and pure vision there is a ranking: pure vision is where how things appear matches how things really are.

Does this bring back a hidden foundation? No. Pure vision is itself empty, the inseparable union of appearance and emptiness. It is appearance free of confusion and of the split into solid subjects and solid objects; it is not a window onto a bedrock behind appearance. In Mipham's presentation, pure vision meets appearances as the mandala of buddhas and wisdoms. This article does not read that as qualities already present in a ground, waiting to be uncovered. It reads it as how appearing is met when nothing in it is being fixed. Māmakī, too, has no nature of her own. Pure vision is accur ate not because it finds an ultimate object, but because it sees without the distortion that splits the world into independent subjects and solid things.

5. Echoes in Physics: Rovelli, Barad, and Agreement Between Observers

This way of letting go of a fixed given, without falling into "everything is mind", has echoes in mod ern physics and philosophy of science. They are echoes, not proofs. Emptiness does not need physics, and a scientific description is itself a label, one of the most reliable we have within its own field.

Karen Barad's Agential Realism

- **No things before their relations.** Traditional metaphysics assumes separate things exist first and then interact. For Barad, the things related do not exist before their "intra-action"; they emerge through it.
- **The cut.** Boundaries and properties are set by particular measuring arrangements. The cut does not slice up a world that was already there; it decides what counts as the observer and what counts as the observed in that situation.

So there is no "liquid" sitting there before the cut. The human drinker and the water appear together, in the human situation; the suffering ghost and the pus appear together, in the ghost's.

Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics

In Rovelli's view, physical quantities do not have values on their own. They have values only relative to another physical system, in an interaction.

Critics asked how, then, two observers can agree when they compare notes. In answer, Emily Adlam and Rovelli added a rule called "cross-perspective links": if one observer measures a system and records a value, and a second observer later checks that record, the two will match, as long as the first record has not been destroyed.

Some critics say this rule gives up what made the theory relational, by admitting shared facts. That is less a concession than support for the point made here. Agreement between observers does not require a hidden state that existed before any interaction. It is established through the interac

tions between the observers themselves, by checking across perspectives, much as Candrakīrti's healthy senses confirm one another (Section 2B), and not by anchoring to an absolute substrate.

One caution applies to this whole section. Neither theory should be read as saying that relations are what is really there. Barad makes the "phenomenon" the basic unit of reality; read as a final ac count of what exists, that repeats, at the level of relations, the very substantialism it set out to over come. Nāgārjuna examined contact and connection themselves and found that none of them can be found. Relations and the things related are identified together; neither comes first, and neither is the ground.

6. Different Channels of Contact

If an appearance depends on particular senses, conditions and channels of contact, what happens when a being meets something it shares little or no contact with?

The answer is neither "absolutely nothing", which would make reality private and erase everyday truth, nor a hidden object, which would bring back the foundation. Contact comes in degrees, and what is true for a system depends on which physical and mental channels actually connect.

A. Uexküll's Tick

The biologist Jakob von Uexküll showed that an animal does not live in a general, neutral environment but in its own world of meaning, shaped by what it can sense and do.

- The common tick responds mainly to three signals: the smell of mammal sweat, the warmth of a mammal's body, and hair.
- A pool of clear spring water has none of these signals, so it does not appear in the tick's world at all.

Yet the water is not "nothing" for the tick: **the tick can still drown in it.** It is cut off from the water's sight and meaning, but still connected to its weight and surface tension. This shows why everyday reality is not private to one mind: cause and effect work along particular channels, whether or not a creature is aware of them.

B. Different Channels in Physics

- **Dark matter:** as far as present observation shows, dark matter does not interact through light or electromagnetism, so it passes through the Earth without collision. To a light-based sensor the Earth is a solid barrier; to dark matter that barrier does not exist. Yet it is still connected through gravity: the Earth's mass bends its path.
- **Neutrinos:** a neutrino from the sun can pass through an enormous thickness of lead, on the order of a light-year, with only a small chance of hitting anything. The lead is neither a wall nor nothing; it is a region of very weak contact.

C. The Old Buddhist Accounts

This range of contact also makes sense of the traditional stories, without needing a hidden substance:

- **Subtle spirits passing through mountains:** spirits whose bodies have no coarse density pass through rock without resistance. Solidity is not a property the stone has by itself; it is a resistance that appears only when two systems of similar density meet.

- **The formless realms:** beings in formless meditative states have no coarse senses, so physical things simply do not function in their experience.

The bowl of liquid remains a working reference point. It is not erased from everyday existence just because a being without the right channels fails to register it. But what appears there (a solid barrier, nourishment, burning pus, or an open passage) depends entirely on which channels are active in the meeting. The "reference point" is only the human frame's name for the place where these appearances are compared. It is not a hidden something that turns into them.

D. Between Realms: The Water Offering

The hardest test of this view is contact between different worlds, which Buddhist practice assumes. In offerings to hungry ghosts, water is blessed with a mantra and given, and the tradition holds that it reaches them as nectar. If each realm's world arises within its own karmic vision, how can an act in one world reach another?

Not by a substance that travels. Nothing passes from the human bowl into the ghost's mouth, just as nothing passes from the evening flame into the midnight flame. The giving is identified in the human world: water, a mantra, an intention. The relief is identified in the ghost's world: nectar where there was pus. The two are linked by dependent arising, as condition in one world and result in another, and the link is recorded from the giver's frame, the one that can compare them. This is the same pattern as the cross-perspective links of Section 5: agreement and influence across perspectives, with no common object underneath.

Two cautions. This article does not claim to have proven that such practices work; it asks only what the tradition's claim would mean without a hidden substance. And the mantra is not a power living inside sounds, any more than the power to open lives in a key apart from the lock, the hand and the door. It is one condition among others, effective, if at all, in the way conditions are.

7. The Myth of the Container

Why do we cling so hard to an underlying object? The root of it is the container myth:

1. We imagine space as an empty, ready-made three-dimensional box.
2. We place a solid object in the middle of it.
3. We put observers in the box and assume they must either see the real object or be fooled.

Physics and the Middle Way both take this box apart:

- **Physics:** in Einstein's theory, spacetime is not an empty stage; it is the gravitational field itself, which moves and interacts with matter. In loop quantum gravity, space itself comes in tiny units and is built from relations.
- **The Middle Way:** Nāgārjuna shows that space cannot exist before its defining mark, the absence of obstruction. Space and the things in it are identified together.

When space stops being an absolute warehouse, the puzzle of how one object can appear differently to different beings dissolves. Space, time, observer and observed are identified together, and none is the container of the others. The "web" that connects them is a label too, not a further thing.

8. Why Is There Order at All?

This leads to the last question realism asks: "If there is no ultimate ground, why is the world orderly and reliable at all? Why do things follow laws and repeat, rather than collapsing into chaos?"

The Middle Way answers on two levels.

A. The Everyday Answer

The Middle Way does not leave order unexplained. In everyday terms, order is explained by the reg ular way things arise in dependence on causes and conditions:

- Causes give matching results: barley seeds grow barley, not rice; fire burns and does not freeze.
- Among living beings, shared karma and shared biology shape how the world appears.
- Convention has its own full, working validity. Being empty of a fixed nature does not make it arbitrary or lawless. Emptiness does not cancel cause and effect. Nor is emptiness what makes cause and effect work: **emptiness enables nothing and explains nothing.** It is the other way round. Things never needed a fixed essence in order to work, and something with a fixed essence of its own could not arise, change or end.

B. Questioning the Question

Pressed further ("yes, but why is there a web of causes at all?"), the question makes a subtle mis- take. It treats the whole web of dependent arising as if it were one bounded thing that needs an out side cause.

1. **"The whole" is a label.** A whole or a "system as a whole" is not a separate thing standing next to its parts. It is a designation. Asking for an outside ground for "the whole" is looking for a foundation outside all relations.
2. **No first beginning.** If we invent an ultimate cause to explain the web, it must either depend on something before it (and the chain goes on) or depend on nothing (and then, having no relations, it cannot produce anything). Nāgārjuna shows that dependent arising has no first beginning. An endless chain is a problem only if we are looking for a final resting place. Once we stop demanding a floor, having no first beginning is simply what dependent arising looks like.

The question does not uncover a hidden answer. It runs out of steam.

Conclusion: Working Without a Foundation

Seeing that similar beings see a similar world because they share similar conditions, and not be- cause of a hidden given, is not a fall into nihilism or into private fantasy.

- It is not idealism, because the mind is just as empty, conditioned and dependent as the things it meets.
- It is not "anything goes", because everyday truth works with reliable, checkable regularity along the channels beings share.

What is removed is only the anxious demand for a foundation: the insistence that, beneath the liv- ing display of appearances, there must be a dead, unmoving ballast holding everything up.

This view also matters beyond philosophy. If the hungry ghost's pus is really pus for the hungry ghost, its suffering is not a mistake to be explained away from a human point of view. No point of view owns the real world, so no being's world can be dismissed as "only theirs". This is not relativism: faulty senses are still corrected within each kind of being, and pure vision is still clearer than ordinary vision. But it is why compassion makes sense without a self behind it. Other beings' worlds are as real for them as ours is for us, and emptiness takes nothing away from their suffering, or from the wish to relieve it.

In the Middle Way, having no foundation takes nothing away from how things work. Nāgārjuna puts it in one line, where the key word means "fits" or "works":

> For whom emptiness works, everything works.

And from the experiential side of Dzogchen: when appearances are recognised as self-display, with no solid subject grasping at a solid object, appearing is met as it always was, vivid, unproduced and not found anywhere. Everyday reality does not carry on *in spite* of having no foundation, and it does not appear *because* it has none. It never needed one.